

The Milky Way

Our solar system is a tiny – tiny! – part of a gigantic spiral galaxy, the Milky Way. This is made up of billions of stars, which look as if they have been sprinkled thickly onto the night sky.



Scientists think there are about 100,000 million stars in the Milky Way galaxy, but there may be even more.

Why is it milky?

Before the invention of telescopes, people could not see the stars very clearly – they were blurred together in a hazy white streak. The ancient Greeks called this streak a “river of milk”. This is how our galaxy became known as the Milky Way.

Milky myths

Many myths have developed about the formation of the Milky Way.



Native American stories tell of a dog dropping corn as he fled across the sky.



Hindu myth sees the milky as the speckled belly of a dolphin.



Kalahari bushmen say it was created by hot embers thrown up from a fire.



The ancient Egyptians believed the stars were a pool of cow's milk.

Become an expert

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A side view

The Milky Way, like all spiral galaxies, is flat, with a bulge at the centre, and arms that circle outwards.